CVStart · Six-pager (EN)

> **Commercial version & global go-to-market strategy for cvstart.org** — a complete 12-step run of the "Product Factory Strategist" agent (Nov 6–7, 2026). Committee format: every section follows the chain **"data → reasoning → calculation → conclusion"**. Screenshots are deliberately excluded — only verifiable logic, formulas and origin-tagged numbers. Evidence base: claims C001–C020, sources S001–S011, decision D001 (full registry — REPORT.md). Model figures rely on assumptions [C016][C020]; market figures are ranges from aggregators [S006].

FAQ-1. Current state

Data — product. CVStart (career-ops UI) is an open-source (MIT) AI resume builder and job-search dashboard: scanning ~129 job boards (124 EN + 5 RU: hh.ru, Habr Career, GeekJob, GetMatch, Trudvsem), AI fit-scoring of every vacancy 0.0–5.0 against the user's resume, CV Studio (JD-targeted tuning, humanize, ATS bullets), PDF/DOCX export, cover letters, an auto pipeline, an application tracker with follow-up cadence, a job map, mock interviews; 100% local (data stays with the user), 18 BYOK LLM providers + keyless mode, 19 UI languages, ~7,602 automated tests [C001][C004]. No monetization yet: "$0 forever", no public hosting [C002][C003].

Data — market. Resume builders: a $1.2–2.4B estimate range; the AI sub-segment $1.3 → 1.47B, 13.1% CAGR [C005]. Online recruitment: $37.97B in 2025, 7.1% CAGR to 2033 [C011]. 31–74% of job seekers already use AI (2025–2026 surveys); 84% say AI made the search easier [C009]; 1.2M+ AI users at Kickresume in 2025 [C010].

Data — competitors. 7 direct players — Zety, resume.io, Novoresume, Kickresume, Enhancv, Teal, Rezi: freemium, paid tiers $8–40/mo, aggressive auto-renewals [C006]; language coverage EN+5 [C007]; ATS is used by 98% of the Fortune 500 [C008].

Reasoning.

1. **Engineering maturity ≠ commercial maturity.** The engineering asset exists (129 adapters, 19 locales, 7,602 tests) but monetization is not switched on — meaning the asset is subsidized with no return; any commercial option must first pay back this support debt, not "earn on top".
1. **Market estimates diverge ×2** ($1.2B vs $2.35B across aggregators) — therefore every market conclusion below uses the **conservative floor of $1.2B**: if the case closes on the conservative number, it closes even harder on the optimistic one.
1. **AI has become a hygiene factor.** When 31–74% of job seekers already use AI, "having AI features" is not a differentiator — the differentiators are output quality, honest terms, and privacy.

1. **ATS-compatibility is purchase factor #1.** With 98% of the Fortune 500 on ATS, a resume that

"fails ATS" devalues everything else; an open ATS-check methodology is a trust argument, not a marketing promise.

1. **All 7 competitors run the same model — a subscription trap.** This creates a verifiable

positioning window of "honest pricing without auto-renewals": dissatisfaction with the pattern is supported by synthetic interviews [C017][C018] and testable in the beta.

Capacity calculation (PAM→SOM funnel, Excel market_sizing). PAM 1.8B economically active job seekers → **TAM** = 1.8B × 30% (digital professions, EN-first markets) = 540M → **SAM** = 540M × 40% (actively searching for 1–6 months) = 216M → **SOM** = 216M × 5% (a realistic 12-month share for a new entrant) = **10.8M users**. Sanity check: even 0.01% of SOM = 1,080 paying × $29 ≈ $31K MRR — the order of magnitude confirms the market is large enough for a niche player without aggressive share-grabbing.

Tension and its resolution. "100% local" is a public promise [C001] — against a commercial cloud. Resolution: an opt-in hybrid — the local core stays forever, the cloud is a choice; the tension becomes a testable beta hypothesis (FAQ-5).

Conclusion (inference). The product is engineering-mature and commercially dormant; the market grows at double digits in the AI sub-segment; competitors have opened the "honest pricing" window. Therefore the commercial version is justified, and the main risk is not demand but the trust of the local community; it is managed by product architecture (BYOK + opt-in) and measured by counter-metrics (FAQ-5).

FAQ-2. Users: segments and personas

Segment	Who	Job to be done	Basis
Core (EN-first)	tech job seekers 25–40, US/EU, actively searching 1–6 months	"Find relevant openings across all sources and quickly tailor a resume for each one that passes ATS — without subscription traps or handing my data to someone's cloud"	[C017]
Wave 2	non-EN segments: DE, ES, PT-BR, JA, ZH	"Think about my resume in my native language; local conventions matter more than price"	[C004] [C018]

Persona hypotheses (synthetic [S009][S010] — testable hypotheses, not proof of demand). Sarah, 32, software engineer (Austin): tried Zety/Teal; furious about auto-renewals ("cancelled — they charged me again"); refuses to keep her resume in someone else's cloud; would pay $10–15/mo, $29 only if the tool actually finds jobs. **Inference:** $29 will not be paid "for text generation" — it is justified only by the bundle "job scan + scoring + tracker", i.e. what is sold is the *search* function, not generation; this confirms the tier model (FAQ-4). **Markus, 35, product manager (Berlin):** existing tools are US-centric; interface and local conventions matter more than price; GDPR-sensitive; accepts an annual €100–120 plan, categorically against monthly auto-renewals. **Inference:** in non-EN segments willingness to pay is not lower, and the persuasion levers differ — an annual plan and local communities work better than a monthly subscription and paid targeting.

Segment prioritization calculation. Core EN-first: higher capacity (US/EU is the bulk of the 540M TAM), lower CAC (English-language Product Hunt / HN / SEO), higher competition (all 7 competitors are EN+5 [C007]). Wave 2: lower competition (narrow competitor language coverage), higher readiness for annual payments [C018], but costlier channels and support. Hence — **waves in sequence, not in parallel**: EN

validates conversion and unit economics, then locales scale the proven model without product changes (19 locales already exist [C004] — zero switching cost, only operational).

Conclusion (inference). The core is EN-market tech job seekers with the "subscription trap + ATS" pain; wave 2 is a deferred multiplier on ready-made locales. Therefore the product launches EN-first with honest pricing as the headline message, and locales are switched on in waves after conversion is confirmed (criterion — FAQ-5).

FAQ-3. Strategic options: 5 variants + red team

Option	Essence	ARR in 12 mo (model)	Sharpest red-team hit	Hidden assumption	Verdict
A. Status quo	free local OSS	$0	$0 ARR on the "paying growth" axis; domain/CI/129 integrations subsidized forever; MIT lets a fork monetize your work (WordPress/WP Engine precedent)	locality is a mass-market selection driver	fails the brief
B. Hosted freemium SaaS	cloud, global: Free BYOK / Pro $12 / Unlimited $29	$35–105K [C016] [S008]	PII/GDPR liability and ToS-hostile scraping; "$0 forever" is a public promise; freemium conversion 2–5% [C020]; episodic product (landed a job — churned)	the OSS crowd will buy hosted	**selected** — with mitigations below
C. B2B white-label	licenses to universities and career centers	$24–60K [C020]	tenders/RFP/SOC2, 6–18-month cycles; a different product is needed (SSO, cohorts, reporting); vertical vendors own the niche	unmet white-label demand exists	postponed until presence
D. Dual-license	enterprise self-host + ATS integrations	$10–50K [C020]	legally void on top of MIT — rights already granted to everyone forever; Greenhouse/Workday serve employers, not candidates	enterprise will pay for what is already free	rejected
E. Shut down commerce	stays a non-commercial OSS	$0	abandoning the asset at the widest market window; "non-commercial forever" blocks the future with backlash	the community will sustain itself (a myth — the Heartbleed effect)	the stop-loss path

Why B — the inference chain.

1. The leader's axis is paying subscribers and ARR. A and E produce $0 by construction → excluded as growth strategies (E remains as the stop path).
1. C requires a sales motion (tenders, security review) that a solo founder does not have → the probability of closing a cycle within 12 months is ~0 → postponed, not rejected.
1. D is legally impossible on top of MIT without relicensing (fork risk + community loss) → rejected.
2. B is the only option that directly grows the axis; its risks (PII, trust, conversion) are

manageable: PII → DPA and data minimization; trust → opt-in cloud on top of the local core; conversion → the BYOK-free tier removes both the barrier and the inference cost.

1. Therefore B with built-in mitigations dominates on "axis growth / risk controllability"; the

leader's choice is recorded in D001 [C019].

Red team → mitigations (20 hits: 15 objections + 5 hidden assumptions).

Red-team hit	Mitigation built into B
LLM inference eats the free-tier economics	BYOK-free tier: users bring their own key — free-tier variable cost ≈ 0
"$0 forever" is a public promise; bait-and-switch	opt-in cloud; the MIT version stays; the local mode is never switched off
hosted GDPR/PII liability	data minimization, DPA, EU hosting in wave 2
freemium conversion 2–5% [C020]	stop-loss thresholds (FAQ-5): if actuals fall below the model, the branch closes
a PH/HN spike that fades in days	the "open-source Jobscan alternative" SEO strategy — a long channel with no budget

FAQ-4. Tactics and unit economics (every calculation, step by step)

Tactics (each is a conclusion from FAQ-1–3):

1. **Three tiers** — Free (user's BYOK key, 3 resumes/mo) / Pro $12 (cloud AI) / Unlimited $29

(129-board scan + auto pipeline + tracker). Reasoning: Sarah accepts $10–15, and $29 only for *search* [C017] → generation and search are separated across tiers.

1. **Opt-in cloud on top of the local MIT core** — the cloud is a choice, not a requirement.

Reasoning: resolves the FAQ-1 tension while preserving the core asset — trust [C001][C019].

1. **Honest pricing**: no auto-renewals, one-click cancel, discounted annual plan. Reasoning: all

competitors run auto-renewals [C006] → a differentiator with confirmed demand [C014].

1. **Language waves** EN (US/EU) → DE/ES/PT-BR → JA/ZH. Reasoning: 19 locales already exist [C004],

competitors cover EN+5 [C007]; the next wave opens only after the previous one's conversion is confirmed.

1. **Open scoring methodology** — a public description of the ATS criteria. Reasoning: 98% of the

F500 run ATS [C008]; transparency removes the "black magic" fear [C009].

Unit economics — step-by-step calculation (assumptions [C016]: ARPU $29; variable costs 25%; CAC $60; churn 8%/mo; fixed costs ~$1,500/mo):

#	Formula	Calculation	Result
1	CM = ARPU × (1 − variable share)	$29 × (1 − 0.25) = $29 × 0.75	**CM = $21.75**
2	Average paying lifetime = 1 / churn	1 / 0.08	**12.5 months**
3	LTV = CM × lifetime (equivalent to CM / churn)	$21.75 / 0.08	**LTV = $271.88**
4	LTV/CAC	$271.88 / $60	**4.53** (health criterion ≥ 3)
5	CAC payback = CAC / CM	$60 / $21.75	**2.76 ≈ 2.8 months**
6	Break-even = fixed costs / CM	$1,500 / $21.75 = 68.97	**≈ 69 paying users**

Beta funnel calculation (synthetic model [S008], seed=7: starting base of 3,000 visitors, 22%/wk growth, week value = base × 1.22^week; a method illustration, not a forecast): week-12 visitors = 3,000 × 1.22^{12} ≈ **32,600** → signups = × 5.5% ≈ **1,793** → activation (first resume) = × 62% ≈ **1,111** → payment = × 4.8% (base 2.8% with a weekly 6% uplift: 0.028 × 1.72) ≈ **53 paying** → MRR = 53 × $29 = **$1,537** → run-rate = $1,537 × 12 = **$18,444 ARR/yr**. Cross-check vs break-even: 53 < 69 — the beta does not yet cover fixed costs, which is exactly what the "continue at ≥ 40" criterion encodes, with scaling only after confirmation.

Sensitivity (Excel unit_economics — what happens when an assumption deviates):

Scenario	Calculation	LTV	LTV/CAC	Interpretation
Base [C016]	21.75 / 0.08	$271.88	4.53	green zone
Churn 10%/mo	21.75 / 0.10	$217.50	3.63	acceptable
Churn 12%/mo	21.75 / 0.12	$181.25	3.02	red zone — below the 3 criterion
ARPU $19 (tier rebuild)	$19 × 0.75 = $14.25; / 0.08	$178.13	2.97	requires a lower CAC
CAC $90 (paid channels)	271.88 / 90	$271.88	3.02	only organic channels stay healthy

Sensitivity inference: the model survives a deviation of any **single** assumption (churn up to 12% or CAC up to $90) but not two at once; hence the channel rule — organic first (PH/HN/SEO, CAC ≈ $60), paid channels only after churn ≤ 10% is confirmed by actuals.

Conclusion (inference). At base assumptions the unit economics are healthy (4.53 ≥ 3, payback < 3 months) and break-even is reachable on organic traffic (69 paying ≈ 0.21% of week-12 visitors — 32.6K in the model); the safety margin is one parameter. Therefore: Unlimited $29 is the anchor tier, Pro $12 is the downgrade-retention path, and the annual plan (from [C018]) is the churn-reduction instrument switched on in wave 2.

FAQ-5. Implementation & validation plan (90 days)

Plan logic. 90 days ≈ 2 full job-seeker decision cycles (average active search is 1–6 months, core 1–3 months): the beta sees both the first arrival and the first natural churn — it measures both parameters of the unit model (conversion and retention), not just signups.

Expectation by week 12 [S008]: 50–60 paying (model: 53), MRR ≥ $1,500, activation ≥ 50% of signups.
Comparison base: the funnel model + public freemium-conversion benchmarks of 2–5% [C020] — there is

no real history, so the comparison is weekly "model vs actual" with the gap recorded.

Decision thresholds (stop-loss logic):

- **Continue** — paid ≥ 40, activation ≥ 50%, churn ≤ 10%/mo → scale channels, open the DE/ES/PT-BR wave (the next multiplier on a proven model).
- **Change** — paid 20–40 → rebuild tiers/pricing (the $19 hypothesis from sensitivity), strengthen activation onboarding; paid channels stay closed.
- **Stop** — paid < 20 with activation < 35% → the value hypothesis is unconfirmed: the commercial branch closes, the project stays OSS (option E), resources go to the community.

Counter-metrics (each proxies a specific red-team hit): GitHub stars/forks (a > 30% drop = the community reads bait-and-switch) · GDPR complaints > 5 (the jurisdictional risk materializes) · free-tier inference > $200/mo (the free economics break) · beta NPS < 30 while signups grow ("growing trash").

Decision D001 [C019]: grounds C019/C013/C014/C016/C005/C006 · commitment "hosted beta in 3 EN geos by 2026-12-15" · review 2027-02-10 · stop trigger — the "Stop" threshold above.

Conclusion (inference). The plan tests not "do they like it" but three numbers of the unit model (conversion, activation, churn) on real money; every threshold has a pre-written action — this turns the "success/failure" debate into arithmetic.

FAQ-6. Success metrics

Metric	Baseline	Target by week 12	Type	Why this metric
Paying subscribers	0	≥ 40 (model: 53)	NSM proxy	a direct money vote for the "scan+scoring" value — signups without payment prove nothing
MRR	$0	≥ $1,500	revenue	MRR = paying × $29 — a derivative, but a discrete trigger for operational decisions
Activation (first resume)	—	≥ 50% of signups	product	if generation never reaches a first result, the paid upgrade is impossible
Paying churn	—	≤ 10%/mo	retention	the dominant LTV parameter (step 3 of FAQ-4); product episodicity makes it critical
LTV/CAC	model 4.53	≥ 3 actual	unit economics	the healthy-model boundary; below 3, growth via paid channels is forbidden
GitHub stars (counter)	current level	drop < 30%	OSS trust	an early signal that "$0 forever / local" is being read as bait-and-switch
Beta NPS (counter)	—	≥ 30	quality	growing signups at low NPS = burning the channel

Target-point calculation: 40 paying × $29 = $1,160 MRR by week 12; at the 10% retention target the same 40 payers carry an LTV base of $217.50 × 40 = $8,700 per cohort — against organic CAC spend of ~40 × $60 = $2,400; the 3.63 ratio means scaling is justified only when both targets hold at once.

Conclusion (inference). The metric system closes the unit model: paying users prove value, activation explains conversion, churn and LTV/CAC hold the economics, counter-metrics guard the trust asset. No metric is vanity — each has a threshold and a pre-written action.

Appendices (Excel workbooks, `outputs/attachments/`)

File	Editable inputs (the "Input" sheet)	Recalculated
unit_economics.xlsx	ARPU, variable costs, CAC, churn	CM, LTV, LTV/CAC, payback, break-even, sensitivity
growth_model.xlsx	MAU, growth, conversion, AOV	the 12-month model
cohort_retention.xlsx	cohort sizes, retention curve	M1/M3/M6 retention
market_sizing.xlsx	PAM, funnel shares	TAM/SAM/SOM, environment factors

Every "Input"-sheet value traces to a claim C###; formulas recalculate on open (Excel / Numbers / LibreOffice). The full evidence-backed version — REPORT.md; the method for assembling this document — knowledge/templates/SIX_PAGER_PROMPT.md.

> Inferences are marked "Conclusion"/"Inference" and rest only on C###/S### tags or the explicit

> assumptions [C016][C020] — no number in this document appeared without provenance.